

Group's Novac Technologies was speaking on similar lines when they showcased their tools at the Gulf Information Technology Exhibition (Gitex) in Dubai this October. Novac believes that Indian companies are more comfortable having their own metaverse domain rather than having to buy land in decentralised ones like Decentraland or The Sandbox, and they help them with this requirement. They have over 50 clients in the manufacturing space. For most, they have helped create digital twins replicating the physical models in their factories for training across departments, including operations, human resources, and administration. They have also developed several immersive soft skills training courses in association with a European company called Bodyswaps.

In a media report, Pradeep B., associate vice president, Novac, remarked that financial services companies are also now interested in tapping into the potential of the metaverse for branding and product development. "For instance, banks are likely to have digital avatars of real bank executives alongside existing AI-powered chatbots to help customers during and after office hours," he said.

On the same lines of democratisation, digital entertainment and technology company JetSynthesys announced in September that it has acquired a major stake in Metaphy Labs to offer metaverse-as-a-service (MAAS) to brands desirous of building their own metaverses, with immersive user experiences and meta-commerce as well. JetSynthesys is backed by famous investors like Kris Gopalakrishnan, Adar Poonawalla, and Sachin Tendulkar.

NVIDIA has also fashioned a neat MAAS offering, especially suited for manufacturing industries. NVIDIA CEO Jensen Huang explained in a recent media report that, "When you



Inside Walmart Land (Courtesy: Roblox)

say 'metaverse,' they imagine putting on VR headsets, but it's obviously not just that. You can do that, but you can also enjoy it in 2D. One of my favourite ways of enjoying the metaverse is a whole bunch of robots in the metaverse doing work and communicating with robots that are outside in the physical world. The physical world and the metaverse can be connected in a lot of different ways. It doesn't just have to be humans. It can be machine to machine."

As part of Omniverse Cloud—a suite of cloud services for metaverse applications—NVIDIA is rolling out simulations for developing, testing, and managing artificial intelligence based robots and autonomous vehicles. Omniverse's 3D collaborative tools run on NVIDIA's well-known chips and hardware, including NVIDIA OVX—a computing system specifically designed to power large-scale digital twin simulations, which replicate real-world spaces in a metaverse environment.

Banks too have started banking on meta

After the pandemic, which proved that online services are indispensable, banks and other financial institutions are looking at the metaverse as one more way to stay in touch with customers. The first bank to enter the

metaverse was perhaps JP Morgan, which opened a lounge called Onyx on Decentraland in February this year to engage with next-gen users. Subsequently, HSBC also opened a similar lounge on The Sandbox.

In July this year, Union Bank of India launched its metaverse virtual lounge, the Uni-verse, in association with Tech

Mahindra. Users can roam around the lounge and get information about bank deposits, loans, government welfare schemes, and so on. The bank plans to use the lounge to publicise its products, but does not intend to enable transactions on it in the near future.

Recently, Kiya.ai, a Mumbai based fintech company, launched Kiyaverse—supposedly India's first banking metaverse. Banks as well as non-banking finance companies (NBFCs) can use the platform to create their own in-branch experiences on the metaverse. Users can access the platform through multiple interfaces, including digital banking units, mobiles, laptops, VR headsets, and mixed reality (MR) environments. Through their virtual avatars, users can interact with a virtual relationship manager, and avail basic and value-added services like portfolio analysis, wealth management, co-lending, and corporate banking.

Kiya.ai will also offer various analytics based services to its partner banks and NBFCs. Future phases are likely to support central bank digital currencies (CBDCs) for transactions and interoperability with other metaverses. Open application programming interface (API) connectors with aggregators and gateways will eventually enable a banking super-app and marketplace.

They hope to give users a near real-world interaction experience with haptics-enabled headsets and using the 'Internet of Senses.' The Internet of